Up Close and Deadly

ACCOMPLISHMENT
As the guru to generations of India's toughest soldiers, she has broken new ground in close combat training and close quarters shooting



MANDAR DEODHAR

Dr Seema Rao, *55*
Special Forces Trainer

THERE ARE SOME ACHIEVERS WHO DEFY description, so extraordinary are the different strands that make them. India's only woman commando trainer, Seema Rao, is one of them. A lethal force, she has over the years trained 20,000 commandos (two entire divisions, if you will)—without any compensation. Seema has also studied Immunology at Harvard Medical School and has an MBA from Westminster Business School. As if all this is not enough, she is a Mrs India World beauty pageant runner-up. Her life's work, however, is in the alpha male dominion of special forces combat. The Nari Shakti Puraskar awardee has also been training police anti-terror squads since 2009.

Seema spent her youth in freezing high altitudes, dense jungles and the hostile Line of Control (LoC)—places where she fractured every bone in her body and had two near-death experiences. "Instead of weakening me, I came out stronger and wiser," she says. "We are all capable of immense strength. But some of us give up and some of us decide to not 'let go'. That makes all the difference." The techniques of close-quarter battles (CQB)—her expertise—were deemed crucial with heightened terrorist threats after the Kargil war and made her line of specialisation indispensable.

Seema credits her father Ramakant Sinari, who was involved in the freedom struggle, with being the motivation for her to serve the nation. But there was a time when Seema was frail and delicate. "As a young girl, I was harassed and was scared of confrontation, scared of heights, scared of fire, scared of water...." she Rao. Then, a fortuitous encounter...with her future husband, honorary Major Dr Deepak Rao, who practised martial arts as a hobby, changed everything. First came the black belts in military martial arts (she has eight). She was trained in Bruce Lee's mixed martial art Jeet Kune Do and the Israeli Krav Maga. Finally, in commando training, she found her calling. Seema has served the Indian armed forces for almost 25 years, travelling every month to training locations.

With her husband, she has pioneered a new method of shooting, the Rao System of Reflex Fire. She has trained every elite force—the Para special forces, Navy MARCOS and air force Garud commandos, NSG Black Cat and paramilitary and police commandos. ■

–Pradip R. Sagar

THE ART OF RESILIENCE

"Everyone goes through challenges in life, but the ones who decide to 'hold ground' are the ones who make it to the top"

WHEN NOT IN COMBAT Practises Zen meditation and watches war movies